Verb Tense Matrix: Proposal Defense to Final Defense

1. Tense matrix by thesis part

Thesis part	PROPOSAL DEFENSE (what you plan to do)	FINAL DEFENSE (what you did and found)	Examples and notes
FRONT MATTER			
Abstract	Often not required at proposal stage. If included: present tense for the problem and purpose; future tense for the planned method.	Past tense for what was done and found. Present tense for general conclusions and implications.	**Proposal:** *This study aims to examine… Survey data will be collected from 200 students.* **Final:** *This study examined… A total of 190 respondents completed the survey. Results suggest…* **Note:** A common proofreading error is leaving proposal-stage future tense in the final abstract.
INTRODUCTION			
Background of the study	Present tense for current facts and situations. Present perfect for trends that continue to now.	Same as proposal (usually unchanged). Past tense only for specific, completed past events.	*Social media use is widespread among senior high students. Studies have linked heavy use to lower sleep quality.*
Statement of the problem, objectives, hypotheses	Present tense (the study seeks / aims / intends to…).	Usually unchanged (present tense). A few manuals ask for past tense in the final; follow yours.	*This study seeks to determine… Null hypothesis: There is no significant difference between…* **Note:** Some manuals write objectives with future tense in the proposal ("will determine"). Check first.
Significance, scope and delimitation	Present tense, with modals (may, could, can) for expected benefits.	Unchanged. Modals stay the same; they refer to possibilities, not to the proposal.	*The findings may benefit school administrators. The study covers Grade 11 students enrolled in SY 2025–2026.*
Definition of terms	Present tense.	Present tense (unchanged).	*Burnout refers to a state of physical and emotional exhaustion.* **Note:** Common convention; not tense-specific in most manuals.
Statements that preview the document	Present or future tense.	Present (or future for later chapters). Use past only when pointing back to earlier text.	*In this chapter, I describe… / In Chapter 4, I will present… / Chapter 1 included the research questions.*
REVIEW OF RELATED LITERATURE AND FRAMEWORK			
Specific studies by named authors	Past tense (APA style).	Same as proposal (usually unchanged).	*Jones (2018) found that… Patterson (2017) reported…* **Note:** Present tense is acceptable if the finding still holds true, and in MLA/humanities styles.

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Trends and body of research	Present perfect.	Same as proposal.	*Researchers have used this method since it was developed.*
Established facts and theories	Present tense.	Same as proposal.	*Self-determination theory posits that… The theory remains influential.*
Theoretical / conceptual framework	Present tense (theory says, the study is anchored on…).	Same as proposal.	*This study is anchored on Bandura's social learning theory, which explains that…*
Synthesis and research gap	Present and present perfect.	Same as proposal.	*However, few studies have examined this in the local context.*
METHODOLOGY (the biggest tense change)			
Research design, locale, respondents, sampling, instruments	Future tense (will be / will use).	Past tense (was / were / used).	**Proposal:** *The respondents will be 200 Grade 11 students chosen through stratified sampling.* **Final:** *The respondents were 190 Grade 11 students chosen through stratified sampling.* **Note:** Note that the number often changes between proposal and final. Update it.
Data-gathering procedure	Future tense.	Past tense.	**Proposal:** *The researcher will seek permission from the principal.* **Final:** *The researcher sought permission from the principal.*
Statistical treatment / data analysis	Future tense.	Past tense.	**Proposal:** *Data will be analyzed using the mean and t-test.* **Final:** *Data were analyzed using the mean and t-test.* **Note:** General facts about a method or test stay in present tense: "The Likert scale measures agreement."
Ethical considerations	Future tense for planned steps.	Past tense for steps taken (e.g., ethics clearance obtained). Present for standing rules.	**Proposal:** *Participants will sign an informed consent form.* **Final:** *Participants signed an informed consent form.*
Timeline, Gantt chart, budget	Future tense.	Usually removed from the final manuscript.	*Data collection will begin in March.*
RESULTS, ANALYSIS, AND DISCUSSION (written only after the proposal)			
Presentation of results	Not yet written. Preview only, in future or present tense.	Past tense for what respondents did or scored and what the analysis showed.	*The respondents rated their sleep quality as poor (M = 2.1). Test scores improved significantly.* **Note:** Many manuals accept present tense for pointing to a table or figure ("Table 1 shows…"). Check with your adviser.
Discussion / interpretation	Not yet written.	Present tense for interpretation and implications. Past tense for	*This result is consistent with Jones (2018), who found… These findings suggest that…*

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		your own findings and for cited studies' reported findings.	
SUMMARY, CONCLUSIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS			
Summary of findings	Not yet written.	Past tense.	*The study found that…*
Conclusions	Not yet written.	Past tense for what the study found; present tense for general conclusions. Manuals differ.	*It was concluded that… / Students experience higher stress during examinations.*
Recommendations	Not yet written.	Present tense with should, or subjunctive. Future tense for actions later readers will take.	*It is recommended that future researchers include other populations. Future studies should…*
Limitations	Present or modal (this study may be limited by…).	Past tense for what actually happened; present for inherent limits.	*The study was limited to one school. Self-report data may reflect bias.*

2. Tense quick reference

Tense	Typical use in a thesis	Example
Simple present	General truths, theories, implications, discussion	*Research methods include qualitative and quantitative approaches.*
Simple past	Completed actions at a specific time: your procedure, results, specific cited studies	*I collected data in 2025. Zimbardo (1998) researched…*
Present perfect	Actions at an unspecified time that still matter now: literature trends	*Numerous researchers have used this method.*
Simple future	Planned actions in a proposal; future recommendations in a final	*I will conduct semistructured interviews.*
Past perfect	Something that happened before another past event	*The sample consisted of 12 students who had completed three courses.*
Modals (may, could, can)	Possibilities, expected benefits, implications (same in proposal and final)	*The results may serve to increase awareness of…*

3. Converting proposal to final: checklist

1. Search the document for the word “will”. Do not use Replace All.
2. For each “will”, decide: is it describing your own procedure (change to past), previewing upcoming text (keep), or a possibility or recommendation (keep)?
3. Change “will be” to “was/were” and check the nearby verbs too (e.g., present perfect “have completed” becomes past perfect “had completed”).
4. Delete mentions of “the proposed study”, “the proposal”, and planned numbers, and replace them with actual figures.
5. Update the abstract, Chapter 1 preview sentences, and Chapter 3 introduction. These are the places most likely to keep old wording.
6. Read each paragraph for unplanned tense shifts, especially after adding supervisor or panel revisions.